

Chapter 4

Genericity and habituality in Czech

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In Slavic languages, the domain of genericity (and habituality) is traditionally viewed as associated with contextually determined meanings of imperfective forms, and to a lesser extent of perfective forms. What has so far remained largely unexplored, and misunderstood, is the verb marker *-va-*, which is dedicated to deriving verbs that only have a generic (and habitual) interpretation. Based mainly on Czech data, it will be shown that the verb marker *-va-* has distributional and semantic properties that preempt its analysis as a marker of tense and/or aspect (*pace dahl1995*, i.a.). Neither can its meaning be reduced to standard (modal) operators that are used in the analysis of progressive or imperfective aspect (*pace suggestions in cable2022*, i.a.). Its quantificational and modal (intensional) components strongly suggest that it is a type of generic marker delimiting a subclass of generic sentence. The insights here reached should support the view that generic markers in natural languages not only exist, but are not as rare as is generally thought, and by the same token also bolster independent arguments made elsewhere for the independence of genericity (and habituality) from the categories of the TMA (tense, modality, aspect) system.

1 Main data and questions

Generic sentences are sentences like *Dogs bark*, *Sugar dissolves in water*, *Sam walks to school on Mondays*. This chapter focuses on their encoding in Slavic languages that have a dedicated marker on the verb enforcing only a generic reading of a sentence, besides using imperfective, and also perfective, verbs for this purpose in an appropriate context triggering their generic (and habitual) interpretation. Its instantiation in Czech (West Slavic language), for instance, is treated as a suffix in standard reference grammars (see e.g. *petr1986mluvnice*,

dahl1995, Kosek2014, nuebler2017, for instance); while some Bohemists treat it as an infix (e.g., kucera1981aspect, bily1986iterative). In Genis2021, it is treated as an infix across different Slavic languages.¹ Henceforth, I will use *-va-* as its citation form (as is also common in Bohemistics), and refer to it as the MORPHEME *-va-* or MARKER *-va-*, given that trying to resolve the suffix-infix controversy would go well beyond the scope of this contribution.

This marker is attested in all Slavic languages (see Genis2021 for examples from different Slavic languages). However, it is productive only in West Slavic languages, specifically in Czech, Slovak and to a lesser extent in Polish, and commonly used in both spoken and written language (see e.g., sirokova1963, Comrie1976, kucera1981aspect, bily1985preliminaries, bily1986iterative, petr1986mluvnice, Genis2021, among others).² In East and South Slavic languages it is also attested, but it is reported to be largely unproductive, at least in their standard varieties.³

Here, the main focus is on the instantiation of this Slavic marker in Czech. The constraints on the length of this chapter prohibit me from adducing relevant examples from other Slavic languages. To the extent that the relevant generic verb forms exist in East and South Slavic languages, e.g., *pisyvati* in Russian, meaning ‘to write repeatedly, sporadically, as a rule’ (albeit judged as archaic), it is reasonable to expect that the arguments made here for the corresponding Czech forms, e.g., *psávat*, should apply to them, as well.

Let me start with a few examples, given below:

- (1) a. Psi štěkají. IPFV
 dogs bark
 ‘Dogs bark.’ [Intended interpretation: ‘Dogs as a kind have the characterizing property of barking.’]

¹Genis2021: “[T]he most common infix in this [habitual, frequentative/iterative, HF] function across languages seems to be one that might be rendered *-va/-*.”

²The productivity of *-va-* in Czech is also evident in the observation that children use verbs on which it occurs early in their language acquisition, even before they master the grammatical perfective/imperfective distinction (chmelickova2005).

³In standard spoken and written Russian, the generic marker only occurs on some verbs that are taken to be marginal in use (Comrie1976, who cites isacenko1962). They are attested in fixed collocations (e.g., *V žizni tak byvaet* [gloss: in life so be.GEN.3.SG.PRS] ‘That’s how life goes. / That’s life.’). Dickey2000 claims that in standard Serbian explicitly “habitual” (in his terms, generic in my terms) verbs can be formed with the morpheme *-va-* (which is an infix, according to him) from biaspectual verbs, e.g.: *kršćavati* (from *krstiti*^{PFV/IPFV} ‘baptize’); *noćivati* (from *nočiti*^{PFV/IPFV} ‘spend the night’); *ručavati* (from *ručati*^{PFV/IPFV} ‘eat lunch’); *večeravati* (from *večerati*^{PFV/IPFV} ‘eat dinner’). However, Dickey’s claim is contested in Genis2021: “[A]ccording to our observations, these verbs do not always have a habitual interpretation but can be used in a durative meaning, as well; other than their base verbs they are explicitly imperfective.”

- b. Psi se *poštěkají*, že ani nevíte, jak k tomu došlo. PFV
 dogs REFL PREF.bark that even NEG.know how to it came
 ‘Dogs bark (out) at each other, and one hardly knows why.’
- c. Psi *poštěkávají* ve spánku, vrčí a cukají packami. IPFV
 dogs PREF.bark.IPFV in sleep, growl and twitch paws
 ‘Dogs bark now and then while sleeping, growl and twitch their paws.’ [i.e., bark a little/on and off]
- d. Psi *štěkávají* na ty, které neznají. GEN
 dogs bark.GEN at those whom NEG.know
 ‘Dogs bark at those whom they don’t know.’

As the English translations of the four Czech generic sentences above show, one and the same English verb form *bark* (3rd person plural, present tense) corresponds to four different verb forms in Czech. All four share the same root *-štěk-* ‘bark’. (1a) is headed by a primary (root) imperfective verb, formally unmarked for imperfectivity, while (1c) by a secondary imperfective verb, which is derived by means of the imperfectivizing suffix (glossed with IPFV) from a perfective base, as in (1b). In languages with the perfective/imperfective distinction like Slavic or Romance languages, the semantics of imperfectivity is taken to have close affinities to genericity (and habituality), based on the observation that imperfective verbs have common contextually determined generic readings, as we see in (1a) and (1c).

However, there is no incompatibility between the semantics of perfectivity and genericity (and habituality). Perfective verbs are also used in generic sentences, and this use is unusual or rare as some assume (e.g., Comrie1976, dahl1995, i.a.). For instance, in Romance languages, and in West Slavic languages (see e.g., filip1997suigenva), perfective verbs have common contextually determined generic readings, as is illustrated by (1b). Here, we have a perfective verb derived by means of the prefix *po-* from the stem of the primary (root) imperfective verb *štěkat* ‘to (be) bark(ing)’ (used in (1a)).⁴

Most importantly, (1d) has an obligatory generic interpretation in all contexts, and unlike the (im)perfective verb forms in (1a)–(1c), (1d) can never be used in episodic contexts. This is due to the morpheme *-va-* on its main verb. It constitutes a sufficient, but not a necessary, condition for the encoding of generic statements, given that, as we have just seen, they can also be expressed by verbs without this morpheme, in an appropriate context.

⁴For a recent study on the use of present tense perfective verbs in Polish generic sentences see wiemer2025.

One of the main goals of this chapter is to argue that the morpheme *-va-* (as in (1d)) is best viewed as a generic morpheme *sui generis* (also building on some previous arguments for Czech in [filip1993berkeleyva](#), [filip1994mitva](#), [filip1997suigenva](#), [Mendia2018](#), [filip2021cologneva](#), i.a.). This argument implies a rejection of the prevalent traditional view on which this morpheme is a marker of a (possibly unbounded) plurality of situations of the same type (see [Genis2021](#), and specifically for Czech see e.g., [petr1986mluvnice](#), [dahl1995](#), [nuebler2017](#), and references therein), and as such, it is treated as a marker that falls under imperfective aspect and delimits an (iterative) *Aktionsart* ([poldauf1964](#), for instance), or as a kind of pluralization operator deriving a predicate of plural situations. While the notion of a plurality of situations is relevant to the meaning of the morpheme *-va-*, it is neither sufficient nor necessary to ground its meaning, as I will show. Given the erroneous idea that this marker encodes a mere plurality of situations, it is traditionally referred to as the “iterative” marker, and also the “multiplicative”, “frequentative” or “repetitive” marker. That its most common label “iterative” is a misnomer at best, and a category error at worst, is evident in the simple fact that this morpheme is incompatible with iterative adverbials like ‘three times’, ‘several times’ (see section Section 4). It will also be shown that the marker *-va-* does not have a meaning akin to the adverb of quantification ‘usually’ or the determiner quantifier ‘most’ (*pace* [dahl1995](#), i.a.), as in ‘in most situations’.

Related to the main argument to be made here, let me make two clarifications. First, terminology for morphemes and grammatical constructions that are used in sentences that express regularities, patterns, habits, in short generalizations of various kinds, is not standardized, and, as suggested in the previous paragraph, often misleading. Iterativity, multiplicativity, frequentativity, repetitivity, usuality, pluractionality, and the like are often used interchangeably, and, what matters the most, also confounded with habituality and genericity.

When it comes to habituality, it is either viewed as separate from genericity, equated with it (e.g., [Comrie1976](#)), or subsumed under genericity as its special case (e.g., [krifka1995genericity](#)).⁵

In its widest sense, the term “habitual” is used for all verbs, VPs or sentences that are not episodic. Episodic sentences are true relative to a given world and

⁵For instance, [Comrie1976](#) uses “habituality” for all the uses of imperfective forms that are not episodic. He divides the semantic domain of imperfectivity into a “habitual” subdomain and an episodic subdomain. However, he confusingly refers to the episodic subdomain as “continuous”, and divides it into two further subdomains: namely, “nonprogressive” and “progressive”. The category “continuous” in ([Comrie1976](#)) is notionally hardly coherent, and formally speaking, there seems to be no language with formal markers for it. For further criticism of Comrie’s classification see [filip1997suigenva](#).

reference time, they do not describe regularities, patterns and generalizations. In this widest sense, habituality has been popularized by Comrie 1976, and is commonly used for one subdomain of imperfectivity, as opposed to its other, namely, episodic subdomain in aspect studies and traditional/descriptive linguistics. Habituality in this sense is, however, problematic, because it subsumes uses of sentences describing what is not generally viewed as a matter of habit at all (Lyons 1977, i.a.), i.e., habit in the sense of regularities of action of typically human, or at least animate, individuals, as in *Fred smokes after dinner*. Some examples are: *Glass breaks easily* (a disposition), *Soap is used to remove dirt* (a function), *Bishops move diagonally* (a rule of a game), *Kim works for the government* (an occupation). Therefore, a better term to cover all types of sentences that are not episodic is “generic”, which is prevalent in formal semantics studies that are informed by philosophy, computer science and psychology.

The Czech marker *-va-*, as in (1d), despite being occasionally labeled “habitual” (e.g., dahl 1995, danaher 2003 semantics, karlik 2017), can formally mark not only sentences that describe habits proper (as in *Fred smokes after dinner*), but also generic sentences with kind reference, as in our initial example (1d), and also in other types of generic sentences that describe what is not a matter of habit (see e.g., (50) below).

Therefore, I will use the term “generic” as a cover term for all statements that are *not* episodic, while habituality will be treated as a special case of genericity (as in e.g., krifka 1995 genericity). The term “habitual sentence” will be reserved for a subclass of generic sentences that concern habits proper, namely regularities of action of typically human, or at least animate, individuals (e.g., *Fred smokes after dinner*).

The second point of clarification concerns the confounding of the Slavic generic marker *-va-* (as in (1d)) with the imperfectivizing suffix (as in (1c)). Their confounding has to do with the fact that some of their allomorphic variants seem virtually indistinguishable, and both are used in generic (and habitual) contexts.⁶ While the generic marker *-va-* enforces a generic reading in all its occurrences, the imperfectivizing suffix on secondary imperfectives is compatible with their

⁶Occasionally this confounding may be also motivated and reinforced by speculations about the diachronic development of one of the morphemes from the other, which, however, seem unfounded. For instance, Kuznetsova 2016 assume, without any evidence and only with reference to some assumptions by kuznecov 1953, that habituality or iterativity is diachronically the original meaning of the Russian secondary imperfectivizing suffix, standardly cited as *-yva/iva-*. According to kuznecov 1953, it developed as the result of a reanalysis of the the habitual or “iterative” morpheme *-va-* of the verb *byvati* ‘to be usually, typically, normally’ or ‘to tend to be’: *by-va-ti* > *b-yva-ti*. Hence, according to him, the imperfectivizing suffix *-yva/iva-* originally only had the habitual or “iterative” meaning component.

episodic or generic reading. For instance, only the imperfectivizing suffix, but not the generic *-va-*, can be used in sentences with a contextually determined progressive (episodic) reading. I will address the differences between these two morphemes in detail in Section 3, and touch on their differences also elsewhere in this chapter.

With these basic clarifications and caveats out of the way, the main question to be pursued in this chapter is as follows:

QUESTION 1: What properties of the marker *-va-* justify its status as a marker of genericity?

The marker *-va-* constitutes a sufficient, but not a necessary, condition for the expression of generic (and habitual) statements. Such markers are attested in a number of typologically distinct languages. An illustrative list, which also includes Czech, is given in **dahl1995**.⁷ In fact, Dahl uses the Czech marker *-va-* as a paradigm example of this class of markers, which, according to him, fail to qualify as generic markers. Instead, they are to be treated as what he calls “habitual tense-aspect markers” that function as a kind of quantifier over situations with the semantics of ‘most’ or ‘usually’. For **dahl1995**, this claim bolsters an overarching argument concerning the reflexes of the episodic/generic distinction in the grammar of natural languages: namely, if all such verb markers like the Czech *-va-* are not generic markers, but rather habitual markers (‘habitual’ in the sense of **dahl1995**) that fall either under tense or imperfective aspect (see also e.g., **Comrie1976**, **comrie1985tense**, **Dahl1985**, i.a.), then “however sad this may be for those of us to whom the episodic/generic distinction is dear, this distinction more often than not is only indirectly reflected in speakers’ choices between grammatical markers” **dahl1995** of aspect or tense.

These are the claims that will be contested here. Contrary to **dahl1995**, I will show that the Czech marker *-va-* has properties that preempt its subsumption under tense or imperfective aspect (also *pace cable2022*, and related suggestions in **chierchia1995**). Its meaning cannot be reduced to a quantifier over situations with the meaning amounting to ‘most’, or ‘usually’, nor any other single expression of quantity or quantification, also contrary to **dahl1995**.

Having established what the marker *-va-* is not, I will show that it derives verbs denoting predicates that exhibit three hallmark properties of generic predicates (see e.g., **carlson1977unified**, **krifka1995genericity**): namely, (i) they are

⁷**dahl1995** gives the following list: Arabic (Classical), Akan, Catalan, Czech, Didinga, German, Guarani, Hungarian, Kammu, Limouzi, Montagnais, Sotho, Spanish, Swedish, Swedish Sign Language, Yucatec Maya, Zulu.

aspectually stative, (ii) have a modal (intensional) import which is tied to the quintessentially predictive force of generics, and as such their evaluation requires access to other possible worlds than just the actual one, and (iii) they express generalizations that crucially involve reasoning with exceptions. This then leads me to the next two questions:

QUESTION 2: What kind of generic sentence does the generic marker *-va-* delimit?

QUESTION 3: What is the relation of the generic marker *-va-* to the phonologically null generic GEN operator?

Given that there is no comprehensive semantic analysis of genericity that is commonly accepted, when it comes to the foundational assumptions and terminology in the domain of genericity (and habituality), I will rely on the theoretical background of the quantificational theory of genericity (see e.g., [krifka1995genericity](#)). Its key hypothesis is that the semantics of generic sentences can be represented by means of a logical (tripartite) structure, where the generic import is captured by means of the phonologically null, modal generic GEN operator, which is akin to overt adverbs of quantification (Q-adverbs) (see Section 2). The quantificational theory of genericity will here serve as a useful point of reference for examining theoretical and empirical issues raised by the generic morpheme *-va-*. It has the advantage that it has a wide interdisciplinary scope, drawing on insights not only from semantics and pragmatics, but also on insights regarding the nature of generalizations, law-like statements and reasoning with exceptions in philosophy, psychology, computer science and other areas of cognitive science.

As I will show, just as GEN, the generic morpheme *-va-* functions as a quantifier over individuals and/or situations, and exhibits variable binding properties that are akin to those of GEN. Moreover, the meaning of both GEN and *-va-* cannot be reduced to any single quantifier over situations, e.g., ‘usually’, ‘most’, or any other quantifier or quantity expression. At the same time, the Slavic generic morpheme differs from GEN in so far as it has two uncancellable inferences: namely, that (i) there are verifying instances in the actual world that count as evidence for the truth of the generalization, and (ii) there are actual or at least potential exceptions or counterexamples to the generalization. The former inference is shared with what are taken to be so-called ‘habitual’ markers in other languages (see e.g., [cable2022](#) on the realization inference of Tlingit habitual morphology), and it is also known as the actualization entailment in the genericity literature (see e.g., [green2000aspectual](#), [hacquardDISS](#)).

The latter inference is clearly manifested in the observation that *-va-* is semantically anomalous or false in generic sentences that have no exceptions in all the possible worlds (such as universal laws of nature), and it must be used in generic sentences that have known counterexamples and would be false without it, all else being equal (see Section 4.1.2). Generally, as I will show, the truth conditions and felicity of generic sentences that are formally marked with *-va-* crucially depend on the speaker's reasoning with exceptions, which reflect the speaker's commitment to the strength of the generalization calibrated in terms of exceptions that (the speaker believes) it has or might have. In effect, generic sentences formally marked with *-va-* are endowed with two layers of modality (intensionality): one that is tied to their generic, law-like, (g)nomonic force, similarly to GEN, and the other to reasoning with exceptions, which may be characterized in terms of the speaker-oriented epistemic and doxastic modality (exploiting general pragmatic principles of interpretation).

The presence of the generic marker *-va-*, and its contrastive absence, in generic sentences differentiate two main types of generic sentences in Slavic languages. Some have argued that different linguistic forms for the encoding of generic statements differentiate different subtypes of generic sentences, each distinguished by different clusterings of formal properties, and possibly requiring different semantic/ontological commitments, and separate semantic/ontological models for their interpretation (see e.g., greenberg2003manifestations, pelletier-equal2009, krifka2012definitional, boneh2013hab, boneh2008habituality). Hence, the properties of the Slavic generic marker directly bear on the fundamental question in the domain of genericity (carlson1977unified, carlson1995truth):

QUESTION 4: Can we provide a unified semantic analysis for all generic sentences?

A conclusive answer to the above question is still outstanding. A unified analysis for all generic sentences is desirable, and hypothesizing that generic sentences might constitute a single class, markers that are dedicated to the encoding of generic statements, such as the generic marker *-va-*, provide some of the best empirical data for evaluating the claims that address the above question.

The proposal advanced here that the morpheme *-va-* is a generic marker *sui generis*, as well as the empirical and theoretical arguments in its support, have potentially significant consequences for the theory of genericity. First, if the morpheme *-va-* in Czech, in other Slavic languages where it is attested, is a generic marker, as I argue, it would shed at least some doubts

on the widespread belief in linguistics, philosophy and psychology that natural languages have no dedicated markers of genericity (see e.g., [leslie2008](#), [Johnston2012](#), [LeslieGelman2012](#), [Rhodes2018](#), [cohen2022](#), [Schiller2023](#), to give just a few more recent examples), or only a negligible number ([dahl1995](#)).⁸ Second, it would support the claims independently made elsewhere (see e.g., [carlson1977unified](#), [schubert1989pelletier](#), [filip1997suigenva](#), [pelletier1997generics](#), i.a.), and mostly on semantic grounds, that the episodic/generic distinction is relevant for the grammar of natural language (pace e.g., [dahl1995](#)), and bolster the view on which genericity is a category in its own right, and specifically independent from the tense, modality and aspect (TMA) system.

This chapter is structured as follows. Section 2 introduces the theoretical background of the quantificational theory of genericity. In Section 3, the formation of generic verbs by means of the generic morpheme *-va-*, and its place in the Czech verb system will be outlined in a theory neutral way. Its properties will be also shown not to be aligned with markers of tense or imperfective aspect. Section 4 focuses on its main semantic and pragmatic properties, which together with Section 3 invalidate the grounds for the claim made by [dahl1995](#) that the Czech morpheme *-va-* fails to qualify as a generic marker. Section 5 addresses the semantic similarities and differences between the phonologically null generic operator GEN and the Czech generic marker *-va-*. The marker *-va-* introduces a modal (intensional) generic operator VA into the logical representation that differs from GEN in so far as it contributes the uncancellable inference regarding the existence/possibility of exceptions or counterexamples to the generalization which, moreover, must have been realized. The use of the generic *-va-* form, when the corresponding non-generic form might have also been used, gives rise to a rank order (see [hornabbott2012](#), [horn2017](#), and references therein), where the non-generic form is the strong alternative (as it allows no exceptions when used in generic sentences) and the generic form the weak one (given that it requires that there be actual or possible exceptions). The rank order generates either the speaker-oriented certainty or ignorance inference concerning the likelihood of exceptions (a kind of quantity-based implicature), which may be characterized in terms of epistemic and doxastic modality, exploiting general pragmatic principles of interpretation.

⁸For instance, [Schiller2023](#) observes: “Generics are present in every known language, but in no language are generic sentences ‘marked’ with an explicit generic operator. Generics are studied (by philosophers, linguists, and developmental psychologists) because of their abstruse formal properties and the important role they play in cognitive development.”

2 Genericity: Kind reference and generic sentences

The domain of genericity is divided into two independent, but related, phenomena: namely, KIND REFERENCE and CHARACTERIZING GENERIC SENTENCES (krifka1995genericity, carlpell1995generic). Some examples are given below:

- (2) a. *Ravens* are widespread. KIND REFERENCE
 b. *Dodos* became extinct in the 17th century.
 c. *Bronze* was invented as early as 3000 B.C.
 d. *The dodo* / **A dodo* became extinct in the 17th century.
- (3) a. *Ravens* are black. CHARACTERIZING GENERIC SENTENCES
 b. *Dogs* bark / *A dog* barks.
 c. Paul plays chess on Saturdays.

There are both formal and semantic reasons for this division. The category of KIND REFERENCE is motivated by the existence of kind-level predicates (KLPs) like *extinct*, *widespread*, *invent* that directly select KIND-DENOTING terms for one of their arguments (in italics in the above examples).⁹ KLPs attribute a property to a whole kind and one which does not hold of its individual members. For instance, in (2b), the property of being extinct holds of the whole kind DODO, and it makes no sense to attribute it to any individual dodo or a closed set of dodos.

The main topic of this chapter concerns CHARACTERIZING GENERIC SENTENCES, or GENERIC SENTENCES for short. Their generic import often arises from the combined meanings of the subject NP/DP and VP, and possibly also in interaction with pragmatic, prosodic (focus), and discourse factors. Generic sentences with kind-denoting terms, as in (3a) and (3b), express a generalization that holds of a kind as well as of its individual members. Generic sentences like (3c) describe a regularity of action ascribed to an ordinary individual, i.e., a habit in the proper sense of this term. While in krifka1995genericity or carlson2011, for instance, they constitute a subclass of generic sentences, some take them to be less typical or marginal members of generic sentences (see e.g. nickel2017).

All agree that GENERIC SENTENCES are fundamentally opposed to EPISODIC SENTENCES. They refer to particular singular situations, as in (4), or to a closed set of plural of situations, as in the iterative sentence (5):

⁹A given language may impose specific requirements on the form of a kind-denoting term. In English, for instance, a singular indefinite is often unacceptable.

- (4) Fido is barking at the mailman. EPISODIC sentences
- (5) Paul played three games of chess last Saturday.

However, there is no general agreement on the positive criteria that delimit all and only generic sentences (see e.g., **Dahl1985**, **dahl1995**, **nickel2008**, **nickel2016**, **pelletier-equal2009**, **pelletier-intro2009**, **carlson2013**). There is some agreement that prototypical examples are ‘bare’ generics like *Birds fly* that involve kind reference in a generic sentence and have no restrictors like Q-adverbs (e.g., *always*, *generally*, *usually*), overt determiner quantifiers (e.g., *some*, *many*, *most*, *all*), modal expressions, or other qualifiers that would restrict the relevant cases based on which the generalization is made.

Moreover, at least since **carlson1977unified**, there has been some agreement that generic sentences, in contrast to episodic sentences, have three main properties:

- (6) PROPERTIES OF GENERIC SENTENCES
- a. All are aspectually stative.
 - b. All have an intensional import, which is tied to their predictive force, with implications for other accessible worlds than just the (actual) world of evaluation, and perhaps all possible worlds.
 - c. Most admit exceptions, but may be compatible with no exceptions.

All generic sentences are uniformly stative, be they headed by (i) generic predicates that are derived from stage-level predicates like *bark*, as in *Dogs bark* (on its generic interpretation), or by (ii) individual-level predicates like *(be) intelligent*, *know (French)*, which are lexically stative predicates (e.g., **chierchia1995**). One standard test for stativity is the lack of reference to particular situations which are locatable at specific spatio-temporal locations. For instance, this is evident in the incompatibility or oddity with adverbials referring to specific time-points and locations:

- (7) a. ? Dogs right now bark.
 b. ? John was intelligent on his porch at 4 p.m.

The reason for the oddity of (7a) and (7b) is that they involve characterizing properties of individuals that hold of them during their whole life-time or at relatively long intervals as well as at any moments of such intervals. Therefore, it is pragmatically odd to assert that they hold only at one specific moment of time or location.

Second, all generic sentences have an intensional (modal) meaning component (first observed by lawler1973, dahl1975), which follows from the nature of generalizations. They transcend our immediate experiences of the world, particular situations, states of affairs, or facts, in so far as they specify what is possible, likely, i.e., they have a predictive, law-like force. This may be based on what actually obtains at given worlds and times, and we might have observed. However, some generics only concern what is *merely* possible and may even never ever be realized, as in (8a) and (8b). They provide the most compelling evidence for intensionality of generics:

- (8) a. The Speaker of the House succeeds the Vice President.
(carlson1995truth)
(Context: The rule of the United States Constitution that has never been enacted.)
- b. This knife cuts cheese.
(Context: The knife has just been delivered in the mail, but its blade got irreparably damaged in shipping.)

The intensional component of generic sentences may be grounded in some underlying causes, principles or factors, or some kind of law that we may surmise behind the pattern, which we may know, but also about which we may be agnostic or ignorant. For instance, *Dogs bark* is true based not just on inductive evidence (e.g., having witnessed barking dogs on a number of occasions), but also on evidence which may not be directly accessible to us, like some underlying causes in the world (such as regularities governing the biology of living organisms) which ultimately ground observable behavior like dog barking.

The third key property of generic sentences is their exception-tolerance. There are generics that admit of no exceptions in all the known conditions, e.g., universal laws of nature like *The Earth revolves around the Sun* or *Water consists of two hydrogen atoms and one oxygen atom*. However, most tolerate exceptions, but may also be compatible with no exceptions whatsoever. For instance, we judge *Dogs bark* to be true, because most dogs bark, even if, as is generally known, there are non-barking dog species like Basenjis and Greyhounds, or individual dogs that do not bark due to injury or illness. These are exceptions that we tolerate. As an extensional consequence, it follows that we cannot validly infer for any particular, arbitrary individual dog that it will have the property of barking. Put differently, that dogs bark is a defeasible fact about dogs. This makes generic sentences particularly amenable to analyses in terms of non-monotonic logics.

What makes any analysis of exception-tolerance so intriguing and challenging is that different types of generic sentences admit a different number and kind of

exceptions or non-confirming cases, while still remaining true. Some we judge to be true based on majority satisfaction, such as *Dogs bark*. However, majority satisfaction is neither sufficient nor necessary for the truth of all exception-tolerating generics. It is not sufficient, because, for instance, (9a) is false, despite the majority of printed books being paperbacks. Majority satisfaction is not necessary, because what is characteristic of a kind need not be prevalent among its members. (9b) holds of only a minority subkind, male adult lions. What is characteristic of a kind may also be characteristic of only a minute minority, as (9c) shows. It is judged true, even if a vast majority of mosquitoes (99 %) fail to carry the virus.

- | | | |
|-----|---|-------|
| (9) | a. Printed books are paperbacks. | FALSE |
| | b. Lions have a mane. | TRUE |
| | c. Mosquitoes carry the West Nile virus (though 99 % do not). | TRUE |

How many exceptions and what kind a given generic sentence will admit depends on a variety of factors which may include not only objective facts of the world, but also our kind-specific expectations, which may be influenced by our subjective judgments about what we evaluate as significant, salient or striking in some way for that kind, like a lion's mane or a virus that is highly dangerous to us. Compatibility of generics with a different number and kind of exceptions also raises the fundamental question about what we view as "characteristic", "typical" or "normal", on the one hand, and what we view as failing to conform to a given generic statement and why, on the other hand.

The above examples and observations should suffice to illustrate that intensionality and exception-tolerance foil any attempt to analyze all generic sentences in terms of a *single* extensional quantifier (over episodic formulas containing free variables) (e.g., *all*, *most* or *some*), a *single* quantity expression (e.g., *in a majority of cases* or *in a significant number of cases*), quantity-based criterion, or statistical criterion/correlation, no matter how contextually constrained and/or modalized they might be, or possibly also defined in vague or probabilistic terms (pelletier1997generics, carlson2013, nickel2013, nickel2017, i.a.).

A number of promising analyses have been proposed for exception-tolerance of generics and related issues, while intensionality has garnered much less attention (see summaries in krifka1995genericity, pelletier1997generics, MariBayssadeDelPrete2013, nickel2017, i.a.). None of the proposed analyses has offered a satisfactory comprehensive semantic framework for all generic sentences, and none so far has emerged as widely accepted.

Therefore, when it comes to representational assumptions, as a useful point of reference and an organizing principle for examining meanings of generic (and habitual) sentences here, I will at various points rely on a logical representation in terms of a tripartite structure with a phonologically null, modalized dyadic operator GEN, akin to overt Q-adverbs, used in quantificational theory of genericity. In its original formulation, it has the following general form (adapted from **krifka1995genericity**, which in turn relies on suggestions in **krifka1987nominal**):¹⁰

- (10) GEN[$x_1 \dots x_i; y_1 \dots y_j$](RESTRICTOR[$x_1 \dots x_i$]; MATRIX[$\{x_i\} \dots \{x_i\}, y_1 \dots y_j$])
 $x_1 \dots x_i$: variables bound by GEN
 $y_1 \dots y_j$: variables bound existentially, with scope just in matrix
 $\{x_i\} \dots \{x_i\}$: means $x_1 \dots x_i$ may or may not occur in matrix

In the tripartite structure (10), just like an overt Q-adverb, GEN relates two arguments, a Restrictor and a Matrix which are separated by ‘;’. GEN stands for a certain characterizing relation between the conditions stated in the Restrictor (which states the restricting cases) and Matrix (which makes the main assertion of the sentence): intuitively, it sets conditions on the number or proportion of individuals that may satisfy the formula, and if the conditions stated in the Restrictor hold, other conditions stated in the Matrix will also hold.

We may distinguish three main types of instances or particulars that can serve as the base for the generalization (**carlson2011**): (i) instances of particular INDIVIDUALS (as in *Ravens are black*), (ii) instances of particular SITUATIONS involving (stages of) a single individual of an ordinary sort (as in *Paul plays chess*), or (iii) instances of particular SITUATIONS involving instances of different INDIVIDUALS that are members of a given kind (as in *Dogs bark*).^{11,12}

The cases (ii) and (iii) involve quantification over situations, which in **krifka1995genericity** is a defining feature of what they refer to as HABITUAL SENTENCES, a subcase of GENERIC SENTENCES:

¹⁰GEN and overt Q-adverbs are not unselective binders, in contrast to their early treatments, as in **carlpell1995generic**, for instance. Which variables can be bound in a given logical structure depends on a number of factors, including context and topic-focus structure.

¹¹The notion of SITUATIONS corresponds to occasions or cases, as **lawler1972** originally proposed, and are akin to “cases” of **lewis1975** (**krifka1995genericity**). It plays a role similar to that of STAGES in **carlson1977unified** (**carlson1977unified**, and elsewhere) which is tied to Carlson’s distinction between stage-level (episodic) predicates and individual-level (stative) predicates (ILPs).

¹²Generics that fall under (iii) involve a ‘double generalization’ (in **carlson2011**; see also **pelletier1997generics**). (3b) *Dogs bark/A dog bark* is true by virtue of (a) *individual dogs* that realize the kind DOG having the characterizing property of barking, and also by virtue of (b) particular *situations* of barking by a stage of an individual dog.

- (11) A sentence is HABITUAL iff its semantic representation is of the form
 GEN[... s ... ; ...](RESTRICTOR[... s ...]; MATRIX[... s ...]),
 where s is a situation variable (krifka1995genericity)

Here, I reserve the term ‘habitual sentence’ to only generic sentences that express habits in the proper sense of the word, as also observed above (Section 1). Most importantly, and as we will see below in Section 4, the generic morpheme *-va-* is not constrained to conveying habits proper, i.e., regularities of action of animate, mostly, human agents (the case (ii) above). Neither does it require that its domain contains situations (the cases (ii) and (iii) above), but it may quantify over individuals only (the case (i) above). In short, it functions as a quantifier over all the three main types of particulars mentioned above, and in this respect it is akin to GEN.

For any theory of genericity the main burden of the analysis is on specifying the relation between the generalization and what it is based on, its basis for generalization, which in many cases (but not all) are some particulars, instances, and particular facts. How this relation comes about is at the core of what it means for a sentence to express a generalization, rule, pattern and the like. We have a rich variety of competing proposals regarding this relation, and by the same token regarding the truth conditions of generic sentences that underpin GEN. One useful way of sorting them out was proposed by carlson1995truth, who suggests that they fall into two main perspectives, and mixed proposals combining some elements from both can also be found. One perspective is characterized in terms of an INDUCTIVE MODEL, on which generic sentences express inductive generalizations that are based on some observed (or unobserved) set of instances or particulars in the actual world from which we infer a general rule. Paradigm cases are sentences like *Paul plays chess* that express generalizations over situations of the kind described by their corresponding episodic sentences like *Paul was playing chess when I called him yesterday*, *Today during the lunch break, Paul played chess with Erwin*, *Last week, Paul played chess with grandpa and won each and every time*. On this perspective, generics would (mainly) express descriptive (weak) generalizations.

The second main perspective corresponds to what carlson1995truth dubs a RULES-AND-REGULATIONS MODEL. On this perspective, generics express generalizations that do not (necessarily) depend on particular episodic conditions in the actual world, but rather on some causal structure or underlying forces in the world, which give rise to episodic instances (if there are any), and motivate the patterns that we recognize in the actual world. Paradigm cases are generic sentences expressing various rules, such as game rules that we may learn directly,

rather than inferring them from episodic conditions in the actual world, for instance, by reading the relevant rules, manuals or guidelines, such as the rules of chess like *Bishops move diagonally*, or following instructions, customs and the like.

In contrast to the inductive model, the rules-and-regulations model can also handle generic sentences that are independent of particular instances or situations, because they have no actualized verifying instances, such as (8a). On the rules-and-regulations model of genericity, we judge generic sentences to be true or false with respect to a set of rules (or a finite list of propositions), which are considered to be irreducible entities, supporting the truth of possibly an unlimited number of propositions.

carlson1995truth proposes that the rules-and-regulations model is a better candidate than the inductive one for a unified semantic analysis of generic sentences, and a model which might ground the semantics of GEN. However, it is not a good fit for generics like *Paul plays chess*, “which lend the most prima facie plausibility to the inductive model” (**carlson1995truth**). A rules-and-regulations model would require us that we identify some rule, causal factor or underlying condition that gives rise to or “regulates” Paul’s chess playing behavior, which seems rather far-fetched.

These two main perspectives raise an intriguing question which of them might best fit generics marked with the generic morpheme *-va-* in Czech, and in generic sentences that are marked with the cognate marker in other Slavic languages. Given that the marker *-va-* requires that there be realized instantiations that count as evidence for the truth of generic sentences marked by it, as I will show, generic sentences marked with *-va-* at first blush fit the inductive model of genericity. At the same time, as it will also be shown, *-va-* can also be used in generics that express rules, regulations, often with the goal of ensuring plausible deniability, or safeguarding a rule, a regulation against refutation by states of affairs of which its author is ignorant. The exploration of the properties of the generic morpheme *-va-* is highly relevant to the answer to the questions posed at the outset: What kind of generic sentence does the generic morpheme *-va-* delimit? Can we provide a uniform analysis for all generic sentences?

3 Morphological background

3.1 The perfective/imperfective and the generic/non-generic distinctions

The generic marker *-va-*, here glossed as GEN, is productive in West Slavic languages: namely, in Czech, Slovak (e.g., *kucera1981aspect*, *bily1986iterative*, i.a.), and to a lesser degree also in Polish (*bily1986iterative*, i.a.). In South and East Slavic languages, its occurrences are also attested, but they may be treated as a part of a lexicalized combination with a verb base.¹³

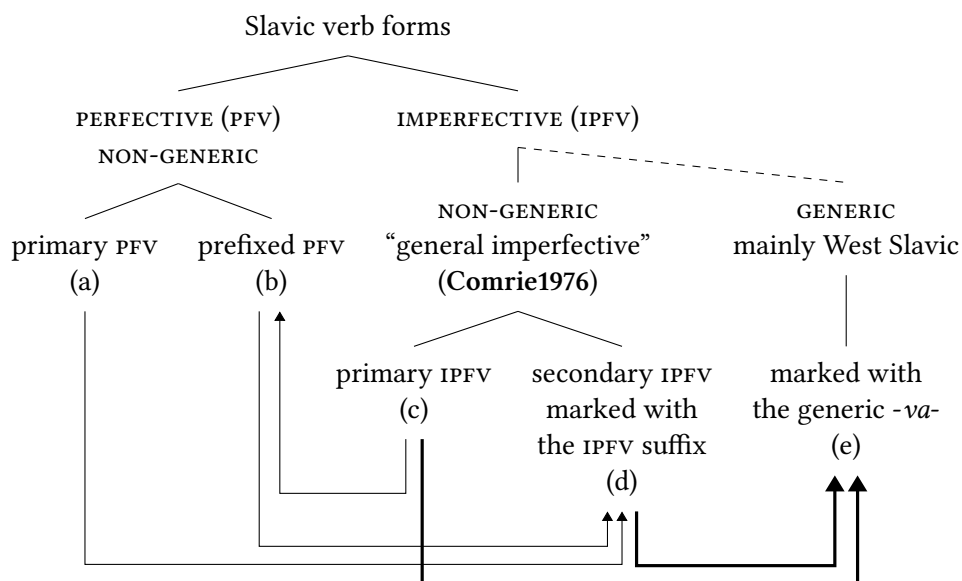


Figure 1: Common formation patterns of non-generic verb forms (perfective and imperfective) and generic verb forms (following e.g. *petr1986mluvnice*). The dashed line: The traditional subsumption of generic (aka “iterative”) verbs under imperfective aspect is not uncontroversial (see e.g. *kopecny1948*, i.a.) and may best be refuted.

¹³In Russian, verbs with this marker are taken to be a feature of a colloquial (“substandard”) speech (*isacenko1962*, *Forsyth1970*, *Comrie1976*, *kucera1981aspect*, *bily1985preliminaries*, *vinogradov1986russian*, *petr1986mluvnice*, *bily1986iterative*), while some of them are in fact quite frequent: e.g., *byvat’* (< *byt’* ‘to be’), *znavat’* (< *znat’* ‘to know’), *govarivat’* (< *govorit’* ‘to speak’), *pivat’* (< *pit’* ‘to drink’), *siživat’* (< *sidet’* ‘to sit’) and *xaživat’* (< *xodit’* ‘to go’). Interestingly, the generic marker similar to that in West Slavic languages is productive in some Northern Russian dialects (*barnetova1956nasobenost*).

Taking Czech as our case in point, in traditional reference grammars, the verb system is structured by two main distinctions: (i) the perfective/imperfective distinction, and (ii) the generic/non-generic distinction. This is sketched in Figure 1, which builds on the rudimentary schema given in petr1986mluvnice. Table 1 contains examples illustrating the different types of verb forms and their morphological relations.

In Bohemistic, the morpheme *-va-* (here glossed as GEN) and traditionally labeled “iterative” (*iterativní* in Czech) or “multiplicative” (*násobená* in Czech) is clearly separated from the imperfectivizing suffix (see e.g., petr1986mluvnice, lamprecht1986historicka, Kosek2014, biskup2024; Genis2021 also separate the cognate generic morpheme from the imperfectivizing suffix in other Slavic languages). However, at the same time, this morpheme is subsumed under imperfective aspect, treated as a kind of imperfective marker, with one notable exception, namely kopecny1948, kopecny1966.

Notice that Figure 1 has a dashed line connecting the IMPERFECTIVE (IPFV) with the GENERIC node. It indicates that the traditional subsumption of verbs with generic morpheme *-va-* under imperfective aspect is not uncontroversial. It is one of the main goals of this chapter to show that verbs marked with the generic morpheme *-va-* do not neatly fit the imperfective paradigm in Slavic languages, and imperfectivity in natural language generally. They have a number of semantic and pragmatic properties that differ from both primary and secondary imperfectives in Slavic languages, which strongly suggest that they have a status that is independent of imperfectivity. This in turn is in compliance with independent arguments made elsewhere that genericity is independent of imperfectivity, and other categories of the TMA system (see e.g., filip1997suigenva).

In Slavic languages, all the forms without the generic morpheme *-va-* that are inherently episodic alternate between episodic and generic readings depending on context. Hence, they are referred to as “non-generic” in Figure 1. Slavic non-generic forms are either imperfective or perfective, and members of both classes can be either simple (root, primary) or derived mostly by means of derivational affixation. Primary and secondary imperfectives correspond to “general imperfectives” (Comrie1976), meaning that they cover the whole semantic domain of imperfectivity, both its episodic and generic subdomains.

Perfective verbs in Slavic languages, all of which are non-generic (i.e., have either episodic or generic uses depending on context), are for the most part derived. Prefixation operating on primary imperfective bases is the most common way of forming perfective verbs. This corresponds to the derivational relation (c) → (b) in Figure 1. Slavic verb prefixes have hallmark properties of lexical-derivational, rather than inflectional, morphology, and hence are not grammatical markers of

Table 1: Examples illustrating the morphological relations entailed by the schema in Figure 1

(a) dát ^{PFV} primary give.INF 'to give'	→	(d) dávat ^{IPFV} secondary give.IPFV.INF 'to give'/'to be giving'
(d) dávat ^{IPFV} secondary give.IPFV.INF 'to give'/'to be giving'	→	(e) dávávat ^{generic} give.IPFV.GEN.INF 'to give regularly, seldom, often, usually, ...'
(c) štěkat ^{IPFV} primary bark.INF 'to (be) bark(ing)'	→	(b) poštěkat ^{PFV} prefixed PREF.bark.INF 'to bark (a little)'; metaphorically: 'to bicker', 'to squabble'
(b) poštěkat ^{PFV} prefixed PREF.bark.INF 'to bark (a little)'; metaphorically: 'to bicker', ...	→	(d) poštěkávat ^{IPFV} secondary PREF.bark.IPFV.INF 'to (be) bark(ing) (a little)'; metaph.: 'to (be) bicker(ing)', ...
(d) poštěkávat ^{IPFV} secondary PREF.bark.IPFV.INF 'to (be) bark(ing) (a little)'; 'to (be) bicker(ing)', ...	→	(e) poštěkávávat ^{generic} bark.IPFV.GEN.INF 'to (tend to) bark/bicker a little, regularly, seldom, often, usually, ...'
(c) štěkat ^{IPFV} primary bark.INF 'to (be) bark(ing)'	→	(e) štěkávat ^{generic} bark.GEN.INF 'to (tend to) bark regularly, seldom, often, usually, ...'

perfectivity akin to bona fide inflectional morphology like tense markers (*pace* e.g. **borer2005**, i.a., for arguments see **filip1992**, **filip2000quantization**, and elsewhere).¹⁴ Slavic prefixation derives new verbs, typically with a different lexical meaning and argument structure than their derivational base. In the relevant examples in Table 1, the prefix *po-* not only derives a perfective verb from the primary imperfective base, under (c) in Figure 1, but also contributes an attenuative meaning to the resulting prefixed verb which roughly amounts to ‘bark (a little)’, and this prefixed verb also has a metaphoric sense of ‘to bicker’, ‘to squabble’. Prefixes are also applied to already prefixed perfective bases, so that more than one prefix can occur on one and the same verb.

Secondary imperfectives (under (d) in Figure 1) are derived by means of the imperfectivizing suffix, glossed as IPFV. In all Slavic languages, the imperfectivizing suffix applies to perfective bases and derives their imperfective counterparts, typically with the same lexical meaning and argument structure. The perfective bases to which the imperfectivizing suffix is applied is either primary perfective, as in (a) → (d), or prefixed, as in (b) → (d), and one and the same verb may contain one or more prefixes.¹⁵

Most importantly, in contrast to the Slavic imperfectivizing suffix, the generic morpheme applies to an imperfective base realized in verb forms that can have either an episodic or a generic reading and derives a form that is unambiguously generic, i.e., it excludes any episodic interpretation.¹⁶ The imperfective base to which the generic morpheme *-va-* applies is either primary, as in (c) → (e), or secondary, as in (d) → (e). When the generic morpheme is applied to a secondary imperfective base, as in (d) → (e), the resultant generic verb contains both the imperfectivizing suffix (IPFV) and the generic morpheme (GEN).

In Czech, the derivation of specifically generic forms from imperfective non-generic ones is transparent, regular and productive, and verbs with the generic morpheme *-va-* are common in all styles of speech (**kucera1981aspect**,

¹⁴The argument that Slavic verb prefixes are not grammatical markers of perfective aspect in Slavic languages provides a key support for the view that the Slavic perfective/imperfective distinction is predominantly of lexical-derivational, rather than inflectional, nature. This is also reflected in the common Slavic lexicographic practice of marking lexical entries of verbs as either perfective or imperfective, and some as bi-aspectual.

¹⁵The imperfectivizing suffix may generate so-called “aspectual pairs”, i.e., two verbs with the same lexical meaning that only differ in grammatical perfective/imperfective aspect. Therefore, some classify it as an inflectional suffix (**Isacenko1960**, **filip1993phd**, **Filip1999**). It is also often taken to be the only marker in Slavic languages that is solely dedicated to the encoding of aspect (*ibid.*).

¹⁶In Czech, the generic morpheme *-va-* applies to past tense imperfective stems (**petr1986mluvnice**).

petr1986mluvnice).¹⁷ The Czech generic morpheme *-va-* can be reduplicated, which also confirms its productivity: e.g., *mít*^{IPFV} ‘to have’ > *mívávávat* [have.GEN.GEN.GEN.INF] ‘to tend to have, very sporadically/very often’, ‘to have once in a great while’. Attested reduplication examples are fairly easy to find, and two are given below:

- (12) a. *Říkávává* se, že po bitvě je každý generál.
 say.GEN.GEN.3SG.PRS REFL that after battle is everybody general
 ‘As the saying goes, after the battle, everybody is a general.’
 b. Bude to z jiného konce, než bývává zvykem.
 will.be it from different end than be.GEN.GEN.3SG.PRS customary
 ‘It will be approached from a different angle than is customary.’

Reduplication is often associated with the speaker’s subjective judgment concerning the regularity of instances that form the base for the generalization. It may affectively connote their strikingly high or low frequency.¹⁸

The formation of generic verbs by means of the morpheme *-va-*, as just illustrated with some Czech examples, follows a cross-linguistic pattern that is attested in a number of typologically unrelated languages that have specifically generic forms: namely, generic forms are derived from non-generic ones; they are the marked case relative to non-generic forms, which are morphologically or syntactically simpler and alternate between episodic and generic interpretations. We do not find generic forms that are basic and episodic forms derived from them (carlson1995truth, carlson2005, and elsewhere).

Examples of languages that have verb markers enforcing only a generic reading of sentences, but are not a necessary condition for the expression of generic statements, can be found in Dahl1985, dahl1995 (and see also above). The Czech marker *-va-* serves as his example par excellence for this class of markers. However, dahl1995 also argues that they are not generic markers, but rather habitual markers falling either under tense and/or aspect; they are habitual markers, because, according to him, a bona fide generic marker must constitute not only a sufficient but also a necessary condition on the expression of all and only generic statements. Only 3 languages in Dahl’s data base of 76 languages have such a generic marker: namely, Wolof (Niger-Kordofanian), Işekiri (Niger-Kordofanian), and Maori (Austronesian) (dahl1995). Such observations constitute one of Dahl’s empirical arguments in support of his main conclusion that the episodic/generic

¹⁷There are also irregular generic verbs: e.g., in Czech *číst* > *čítat* ‘to read’, *vidět* > *vídat* ‘to see’, *slyšet* > *slýchat* ‘to hear’, *sedět* > *sedat* ‘to sit (down)’, *ležet* > *léhat* ‘to lie (down)’.

¹⁸(12a) retrieved at <https://www.vidlakovykydy.cz/clanky/maginitova-linie-ceskoslovenske-opoveni> accessed 13/12/2021; (12b) from a native Czech speaker (p.c.).

distinction has no direct relevance for the grammar of natural language; rather, it is generally only indirectly reflected in speakers' choices between grammatical markers (dahl1995).

To this it might be immediately objected that Dahl's claim here relies on an overly restrictive, unwarranted, requirement of what it means for a given marker to count as a grammatical marker of a given category. As is well-known, bona fide grammatical markers (e.g., the English past tense morpheme *-ed*) do not neatly delimit a single semantic domain, and absolute obligatoriness is not a necessary criterion for grammaticalization, as "[s]omething is obligatory relative to the context; i.e., it may be obligatory in one context, optional in another and impossible in a third context" (lehmann1995; see also heine2002kuteva, heine2007kuteva, and others, for similar observations).

dahl1995 also observes that "[a] relatively safe generalization is that habituals in general exhibit a low degree of grammaticalization. They are [...] possible sources of a grammaticalization path yielding what would be the primary candidates for a gram that systematically marks genericity." In West Slavic languages at least, and as we have just seen in Czech, the generic marker is productive, and systematically in all its occurrences only contributes a generic interpretation to the meaning of a verb, in a completely transparent and compositional way. This would seem to indicate that it exhibits a high degree of grammaticalization.

Having sketched some basic morphological facts, the next section will address the independence of the Slavic generic morpheme from tense and imperfective aspect, and specifically its independence from the imperfectivizing suffix. We will also see that it does not neatly fit into the Slavic imperfective paradigm, contrary to the standard assumptions in Bohemistic, and also contrary to dahl1995.

3.2 Independence of the generic morpheme from tense and imperfective aspect

The generic morpheme *-va-* is independent of tense. It occurs on non-finite forms (including the infinitive and imperative, the relevant examples are given in filip1997suigenva), and with all the overt tense markers (past, present, and future) on the same verb or in the same verb complex, as we see in the following Czech examples:¹⁹

¹⁹In the past tense, generic sentences formally marked with *-va-* have a remote past time reference, whereby its reduplication entails a high degree in the past temporal remoteness (kucera1981aspect, kucera1983semantic, bily1986iterative): e.g., *Vídávával [see.GEN.GEN.1SG.PST] jsem ho tam ve čtvrty* 'I used to see him there on Thursdays once in a while / regularly ... a very long time ago' (chmelickova2005). Generally, *-va-* (possibly also

- (13) a. Karel hrával hokej. PAST TENSE
 Charles play.GEN.PST hockey
 ‘Charles used to play hockey.’ [remote past]
- b. Karel hrává hokej. PRESENT TENSE
 Charles play.GEN.PRS hockey
 ‘Charles tends to play hockey.’ [i.e., regularly, often, seldom, ...]
- c. Karel bude hrávat hokej. FUTURE TENSE
 Charles be.AUX.FUT play.GEN.IPFV hockey
 ‘Charles will tend to play hockey.’ [i.e., regularly, often, seldom, ...]

The independence of the generic morpheme *-va-* from tense is not surprising, given that generally markers of genericity and tense are orthogonal to one another in languages that have overt markers for genericity and tense. There are tensed languages with generic markers (e.g., Czech, Polish, Slovak), without generic markers (e.g., English), and tenseless languages with arguably generic markers (e.g., American Sign Language) and without them (e.g., Chinese), in which case they convey generic statements by other means (e.g., in Dyirbal and Burmese by means of a modal distinction between realis and irrealis; see [comrie1985tense](#)).

Also notionally, genericity (and habituality) and tense are independent of each other. Tense is a deictic category, while genericity (and habituality) are non-deictic. In tensed languages like English, generic sentences can be in any tense form, and refer to present, future or past time: e.g., *Corruption starts at the top*, *Men were deceivers ever*, *The poet will go to any end to make a rhyme*. In English, the simple (non-progressive) present tense, as opposed to the present progressive, preferably has a generic interpretation.

Generic sentences are compatible with any sufficiently large temporal interval, contextually located in the present, past, or future. They may also express generalizations that contain overt or covert spatial/temporal restrictors related to the present, past, or future, as shown in (14).

- (14) a. *Současný prezident jídvá hamburgery.*
 current president eat.GEN.PRS hamburgers
 ‘The current president eats hamburgers.’

reduplicated) combined with the past tense triggers a conversational implicature that the described situation no longer holds, and can also refer to single extended situations in the past.

- b. Dinosauri jídávali kelp.
 dinosaurs eat.GEN.PST kelp
 ‘Dinosaurs (usually) ate kelp.’ [The generalization is restricted to the distant past by virtue of the general world knowledge about the dinosaur kind.]
- c. *Od pondělka* se bude tato kancelář otvírávat až ve
 from Monday REFL be.AUX.FUT this office open.GEN.IPFV only at
 2 hodiny.
 2 o’clock
 ‘Starting next Monday this office will open only at 2 p.m.’

Let me now turn to the independence of the generic marker from the imperfectivizing suffix. It is not uncommon for the generic marker *-va-* and the imperfectivizing suffix to be confounded, both notionally and formally, given that their surface allomorphic variants may often seem alike, and both occur in generic sentences. One compelling piece of evidence for their formal independence stems from the fact that they may co-occur on the same verb (see [filip1997suigenva](#)). Consider the following attested example:²⁰

- (15) Bývalý mi taky *dávával* nádherně a originálně
 ex me.DAT also give.IPFV.GEN.PST wonderfully and originally
 vázané kytice, přímo umělecká díla, ...
 bound bouquets directly art works
 ‘My ex also used to give me wonderful bouquets in original arrangements, real works of art, ...’

In (15), the morpheme sequence IPFV + GEN is the result of the derivation pattern (a) > (d) > (e), given in Figure 1. In the first step (a) > (d) the imperfectivizing suffix (IPFV) applies to a (primary, or root) perfective base and derives an imperfective form, which alternates between an episodic and a generic reading depending on context. Hence, it is unmarked for genericity, i.e., non-generic or a “general imperfective” form (in the sense of [Comrie1976](#)). In the second step (d) > (e), the generic *-va-* (GEN) is added “on top of” the imperfectivizing suffix (IPFV), and yields a verb that only has a generic reading.

²⁰The example is from <https://abecedazdravi.cz/diskuse/psychicke-problemy-a-psychologie/deprese-i-nova-diskuze/89>; accessed on July 9, 2023.